Check, Please

By Jonathan Rand

GUY: **(Pg 301-334)** Hi. It's so great to finally meet you.

MELANIE: *(MELANIE is truly sweet and adorable when she's focused on the date.)* Hi. Same here!

GUY: SO ... What do you-

MELANIE: Wait, before you ... sorry. *(Meekly.)* This is so rude, but the Bears game is on right now? You don't mind if I check the score ...

GUY: Oh, sure. Totally.

INTRODUCTION

Let's face it . . .The dating landscape is a minefield. . . . and let's not even talk about blind dates! The concept of a blind date to me, even in its simplest most casual form just has "disaster" written all over it. You say to yourself: But surely my loved ones and trusted acquaintances can help navigate this treacherous world and find me a suitable mate amongst their social networks. You are wrong. Soooo wrong! Some blind dates take it from simply bad to absolutely horrific.

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MELANIE: *(As she pulls out her cell phone to check her web browser.)* I know this is such an awful thing to do on a first date, but it's late in the fourth quarter, and it's do-or-die if we wanna make the playoffs.

GUY: It's no problem at all. Really.

MELANIE: Thanks. *(As she checks.)* I love the Bears. They're really strong this season. *(Sees score; reacts a little.)* Okay, I'm done. *(Cheerily.)* That wasn't so bad, was it?

GUY: What's the score?

MELANIE: Packers by seven. It's no big deal. It's just a game, right? So, c'mon, enough about football. Let's hear about "Mister Mystery." Harriet's told me tons about you.

GUY: Man ... The pressure's on now. *(They laugh together genuinely. MELANIE laughs then*

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fades directly into her next line, which is suddenly serious.)

MELANIE: I'm just gonna check on the game one more time. *(She digs into her purse.)* Is it all right with you if I put on this little earpiece thingy? It won't be distracting, I promise. *(As she puts the earpiece in her ear.)* I'm making the worst first impression, aren't I?

GUY: Not at all.

MELANIE: It's just because it's for the playoffs. I'm usually pretty normal. *(Throws her hands up.)* Ah! The line gives A-Train this huge running lane, but he fumbles after two yards. The ball rolled out of bounds, so we're cool, but come on-it's for the playoffs. You don't just drop the ball like that, you know? Now you're third and long, and the whole season is riding on one play. PASS THE BALL!!

GUY: What's wrong?

MELANIE: Miller! He doesn't pass it. It's third and long-who hands it off on third and long? Is he suddenly **AFRAID OF HIS RECEIVERS?!** *(GUY looks around subtly at the other patrons.)* Oh my God, I'm sorry. I'm being loud, aren't I. **PASS THE BALL!! Jesus, people! This is FOOTBALL, not FREEZE TAG. It's FOURTH DOWN pass the FRIGGING BALL!**

GUY: Listen, we could go to a bar or something if you want to watch the game on TV.

MELANIE: Oh please, no. I wouldn't do that to you. The game's basically over. *(She takes a deep breath and is now very calm.)* Okay. I'm done. I got a little carried away there, didn't I? Let's order. *(They peruse for a moment, as if nothing has happened.) (Downtrodden.)* They lost ... *(Starting to tear up.)* They lost. *(MELANIE breaks down. GUY takes out a handkerchief and offers it to MELANIE. She uses it to blow her nose.)*

GUY: I'm so sorry. Can I do anything to help?

MELANIE: *(Still weepy.)* The Bears suck ...

GUY: Aww, no. They don't suck. They're probably just having a bad season- *(MELANIE grabs his collar, pulls him extremely close, and speaks in a horrifying, monstrous, deep voice.)*

MELANIE: THE BEARS SUCK.

GUY: Check, please.

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(GUY is sitting across the table from a fully outfitted mime, MIMI, who throughout the scene is extremely over-the-top and exuberant. The scene begins with MIMI "leaning" on "something." Mimed actions in this scene will be indicated with brackets. A few moments pass as we get a feel for the ridiculousness of the scenario.)

GUY: So what do you do for a living? *(Beat.)*

MIMI: *[Pulling something heavy with a rope.]*

GUY: You pull rope. *(Pause.)* Look ... I respect your profession and all? I think it's noble what you do .... The world needs more people who ... climb invisible ladders and pull imaginary ropes. But I really don't see how it's appropriate to bring your work to a date.

MIMI: *[Battling against harsh winds.]*

GUY: Oh, yeah, quite a storm in here. Listen, I'm gonna go ahead and order. *(GUY opens his menu and reads. MIMI gets past the storm and mimes picking up an imaginary menu, proceeding to peruse, turning page after page. GUY looks up. There is silence as he watches MIMI do her thing.)* Hey, I'm gonna go ... use the restroom. *(GUY gets up, takes his jacket from the back of the chair.)*

MIMI: *[You're leaving? Driving away? Far? Bye-bye?]*

GUY: No, I'm not leaving. I'm taking my jacket with me because ... it might get cold in the men's room.

MIMI: *[Cold like me in this wild blizzard?]*

GUY: Yeah, exactly like that. *(GUY starts to leave. MIMI follows close behind, maybe as an airplane pilot or a bus driver.)*

GUY: No, you stay here. You-

MIMI: *[Let me feed some chickens. Awww, those chicks are adorable. I love petting these lovely animals.]*

GUY: I don't know what that is .... Look, I have to- *(An idea dawns on GUY. The following is an extremely loud and animated sequence of events-very frantic for MIMI; sarcastically frantic for GUY.) (Looking up.)* Oh my God! A BOX!

MIMI: *[Where? Where?]*

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GUY: A huge glass box, falling from the sky!

MIMI: *[Oh no! Oh no! I can't see it! What in heaven's name will I do? Help me, Lord!]*

GUY: Noooooooo! *(GUY follows "the box" with his finger as it plops directly on the frantic MIMI, who is now very much "trapped.")* Check, please.

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LINDA: Hi. I've been looking forward to this for a while.

GUY: Me, too. Sorry about all the rescheduling.

LINDA: Pssh, whatever, it's cool. Oh, shoot. Hold on. I forgot to *(She starts rummaging through her purse, and after a couple if seconds, starts removing objects: compact, lipstick, etc.)*

GUY: What's up? What's wrong?

LINDA: Oh, it's this silly thing. I've got this pill I need to take or else I get all weird. *(Back to her purse.)* I know I brought them. They've gotta be-- You know, whatever. I'll be fine.

GUY: You sure? I could drive you to a pharmacy or something.

LINDA: Nah, it's no big deal. It's just a precautionary drug, you know? It won't kill me if I don't take it for one night. I just may be a little out of whack. You probably won't even be able to tell. Whatever. So-anyway . . . It's nice to finally meet you.

GUY: The feeling's mutual.

LINDA: *(Suddenly sarcastic, morose, in a monotone voice.)* Oh, yes. It's so wonderful to finally put a name with a face. How wonderfully fascinating.

GUY: Heh. Yeah. Seriously.

LINDA: *(Giggly/bubbly.)* Hee hee hee. You're funny. You're cute. *(Gruff.)* He's not cute. You just haven't been out in a while. *(Snobby.)* That is NOT TRUE. He is GOOD-LOOKING. *(Bashful.)* No ... No ... He's- *(Sensual.)* Oh, you are absolutely right. He is a hunk of man. *(Jittery.)* Shhhhhhhh ... You're embarrassing yourself ... *(Gruff.)* Quit freaking out, man. *(Easily offended.)* Wha? Wha? Why are you jumping all over me? *(Little girl.)* She started it! *(Motherly.)* Girls, please don't fight.

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GUY: Excuse me. Are you gonna be okay?

LINDA: *(Pissy, to GUY.)* You stay out of this! *(Reasonable.)* Hey, leave him alone. You just met him. *(Gruff.)* Oh, he can take care of himself *(Sarcastic.)* Way to ruin a magical evening. *(Sensual.)* Mmmmm ... The evening's about to get a lot more magical. *(Motherly.)* You'd better behave yourself, young lady, or you're grounded.

GUY: *(GUY notices a bottle under a napkin and shows it to LINDA.)* Hey, are these the pills?

LINDA: *(Cheery.)* There they are! *(Pissy.)* Yeah, too little too late. *(Sensual.)* You are so sweet to find them! *(Peppy.)* Yeah! YEAH! *(Sarcastic monotone.)* Whoop-dee-doo. *(LINDA swallows the pill.)*

GUY: Is everything all right?

LINDA: *(Mostly back to normal, but woozy.)* Whoa. Uh. Okay. Okay. It's starting to kick in. In a couple of seconds, the medicine'll take effect and I'll settle into a single personality. But don't worry-like, ninety-nine times out of a hundred, it's one of the normal ones. *(LINDA suddenly lets out a shriek, grabs some bread from the table, sniffs it voraciously, stuffs it in her mouth, and lumbers offstage. Pause.)*

GUY: Check, please.

(Note: LINDA's personality switches should be fast. Each personality should be a different level- her voice and demeanor should be changing dramatically throughout.)

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AWARD HISTORY

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